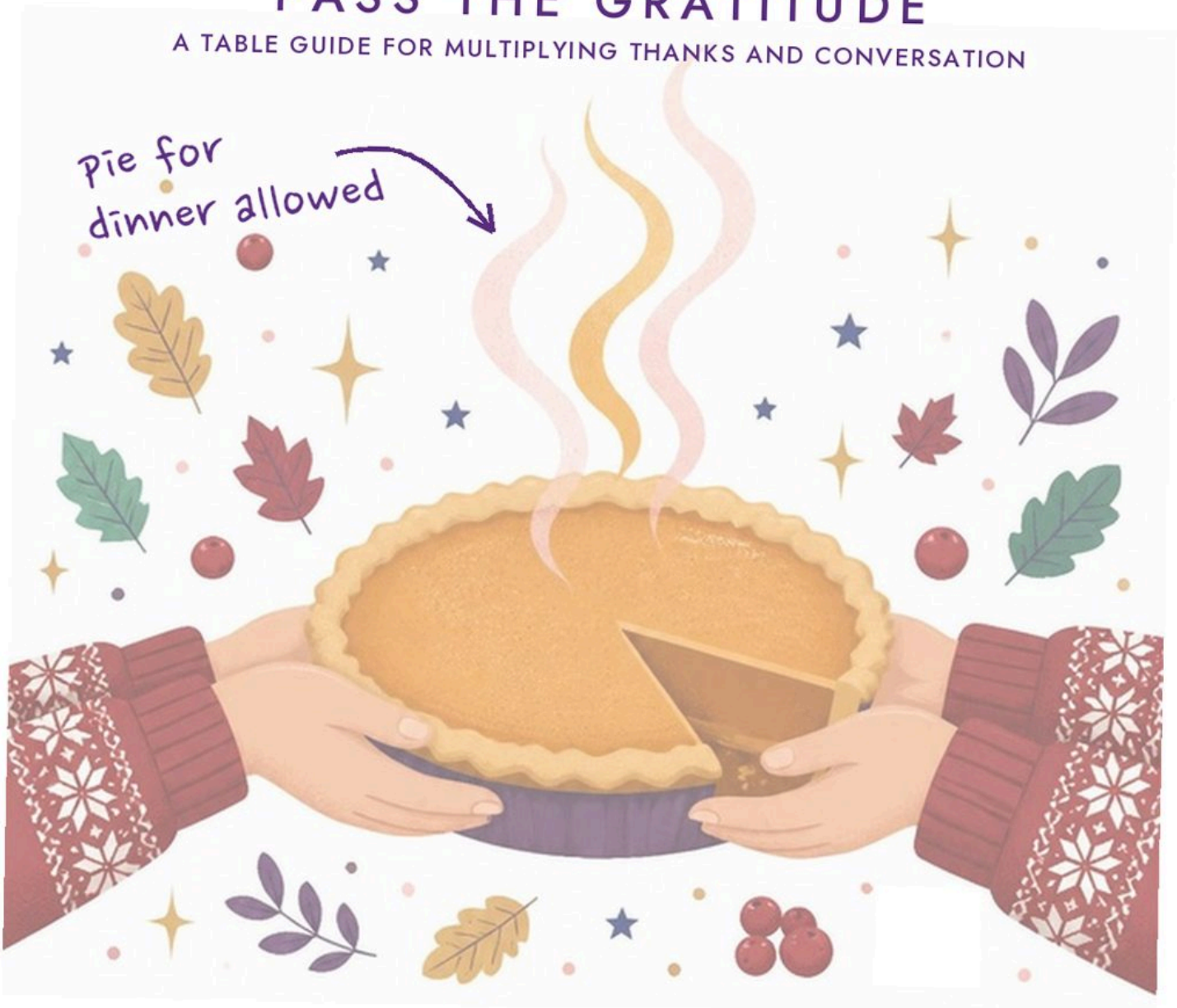
Seconds, Please

PASS THE GRATITUDE

A TABLE GUIDE FOR MULTIPLYING THANKS AND CONVERSATION



Chaotic Sunshine

READ THIS FIRST

Your Table, *Your Rules*

Let's get one thing straight before anyone passes the gravy: there's no wrong way to do Thanksgiving.

Maybe you're squeezed around a table for twenty with the whole extended crew. Maybe it's a few of you and a very small turkey. Maybe it's just you this year.

All of it counts.

Some of you will host every single year. Some of you will never host, and you're the hero who brings the ice. Some of you will potluck it, because one oven was never meant to carry a whole holiday.

This year you could:

- Go all in: the full turkey dinner, a houseful of family and the whole party. Classic for a reason.
- Lace up and take a hike. Pack pie.
- Plan an adventure somewhere you've never been.
- Find a community table and pull up a chair.
- Head to your favorite restaurant or bar and find your people there.
- Invite friends over if you love to cook. Potluck it if you don't.
- Throw out the menu. Tacos and tamales. Greek lamb and baklava. A full vegetarian spread. Nobody's calling the turkey police.

And yes, some of us skip the turkey completely, eat pumpkin pie for dinner and catch a new movie at the theater. Also valid. Extremely valid.

Your Thanksgiving gets to change as your life changes. The season you're in gets a vote. So does your heart.

Use what works in these pages. Read them at a big table, a small one, a picnic table at the trailhead or a bar stool. Skip what doesn't fit.

> *The point is the thank-you, and thank-yous multiply.*

no turkey police here

FOR WHOEVER ENDED UP IN CHARGE

Hey, Host.
Yes, You.

You don't have to do all of this. Print it. Put one page on each chair. That's the whole job.

HOW IT WORKS

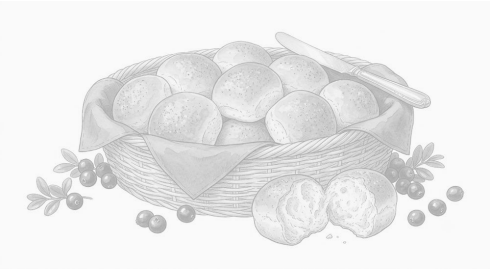
- **One Reader pages:** whoever finds it on their chair reads it out loud when it's their turn.
- **Partner pages:** marked Partner A and Partner B. Find your match and take turns. You read the bold lines.
- **Read Together pages:** everybody, all at once. Slightly off-key is the house style.

Small table? Use the pages with the little sun in the corner. Done in ten minutes.

Big crowd? Use everything. Double up the partner pages and let the kids' table take the limericks.

Turkey dry? Rolls burnt? Somebody brought store-bought pie? Perfect. You're right on schedule.

Thank-yous are the only thing at this table that get bigger when you pass them.



breathe. pass the rolls.



READ TOGETHER

To Begin

PSALM 100 (ESV)

Make a joyful noise to the LORD, all the earth!
Serve the LORD with gladness!
Come into his presence with singing!

Know that the LORD, he is God!
It is he who made us, and we are his;
we are his people, and the sheep of his pasture.

Enter his gates with thanksgiving,
and his courts with praise!
Give thanks to him; bless his name!

For the LORD is good;
his steadfast love endures forever,
and his faithfulness to all generations.

loud is fine. off-key is finer.

PARTNER A: YOU LEAD. READ THE BOLD LINES.

Grace, *Passed Around*

For the food in front of us,
we give thanks.
For the hands that made it, and whoever burned the rolls,
we give thanks.
For every chair filled tonight, and the ones we miss,
we give thanks.
For the long year behind us, the good days and the hard ones,
we give thanks.
For the God who keeps setting a table for us, every single day,
we give thanks.
Bless this food, this mess, and these people.
Amen. Now pass the potatoes.

under 2 minutes.
the gravy is
watching.



PARTNER B: YOU ANSWER. EVERYONE JOINS IN.

Grace, *Passed Around*

For the food in front of us,

we give thanks.

For the hands that made it, and whoever burned the rolls,

we give thanks.

For every chair filled tonight, and the ones we miss,

we give thanks.

For the long year behind us, the good days and the hard ones,

we give thanks.

For the God who keeps setting a table for us, every single day,

we give thanks.

Bless this food, this mess, and these people.

Amen. Now pass the potatoes.

potatoes first.
trust me.



ONE READER

The Party Nobody Expected



who's the welcome-home person at your table?

A son blows his inheritance, hits bottom and heads home with a speech ready. His father doesn't let him finish it.

LUKE 15:20-24 (ESV)

And he arose and came to his father. But while he was still a long way off, his father saw him and felt compassion, and ran and embraced him and kissed him. And the son said to him, "Father, I have sinned against heaven and before you. I am no longer worthy to be called your son." But the father said to his servants, "Bring quickly the best robe, and put it on him, and put a ring on his hand, and shoes on his feet. And bring the fattened calf and kill it, and let us eat and celebrate. For this my son was dead, and is alive again; he was lost, and is found." And they began to celebrate.

ONE READER

Thanksgiving, *Signed in Wartime*

Sarah Josepha Hale, a magazine editor usually credited with writing "Mary Had a Little Lamb," spent 17 years writing letters to presidents asking for one national day of thanks. In 1863, in the middle of the Civil War, Abraham Lincoln finally said yes.

FROM LINCOLN'S THANKSGIVING PROCLAMATION, OCTOBER 3, 1863

The year that is drawing towards its close, has been filled with the blessings of fruitful fields and healthful skies. To these bounties, which are so constantly enjoyed that we are prone to forget the source from which they come, others have been added, which are of so extraordinary a nature, that they cannot fail to penetrate and soften even the heart which is habitually insensible to the ever watchful providence of Almighty God.

I do therefore invite my fellow citizens in every part of the United States ... to set apart and observe the last Thursday of November next, as a day of Thanksgiving and Praise to our beneficent Father who dwelleth in the Heavens.

he wrote this in the middle of a war.



ONE READER

Enough to *Go Around*

Five thousand hungry people. One boy's lunch. Watch what happens when somebody says thank you first.

JOHN 6:5-13 (ESV)

Lifting up his eyes, then, and seeing that a large crowd was coming toward him, Jesus said to Philip, "Where are we to buy bread, so that these people may eat?" He said this to test him, for he himself knew what he would do. Philip answered him, "Two hundred denarii worth of bread would not be enough for each of them to get a little." One of his disciples, Andrew, Simon Peter's brother, said to him, "There is a boy here who has five barley loaves and two fish, but what are they for so many?" Jesus said, "Have the people sit down." Now there was much grass in the place. So the men sat down, about five thousand in number. Jesus then took the loaves, and when he had given thanks, he distributed them to those who were seated. So also the fish, as much as they wanted. And when they had eaten their fill, he told his disciples, "Gather up the leftover fragments, that nothing may be lost." So they gathered them up and filled twelve baskets with fragments from the five barley loaves left by those who had eaten.

Twelve baskets of leftovers. Heaven does Tupperware too.

PARTNER A: READ THE BOLD LINES.

His Love *Endures Forever*



PSALM 136:1-5, 23-26 (ESV)

Give thanks to the LORD, for he is good,
for his steadfast love endures forever.

Give thanks to the God of gods,
for his steadfast love endures forever.

Give thanks to the Lord of lords,
for his steadfast love endures forever.

to him who alone does great wonders,
for his steadfast love endures forever.

to him who by understanding made the heavens,
for his steadfast love endures forever.

It is he who remembered us in our low estate,
for his steadfast love endures forever.

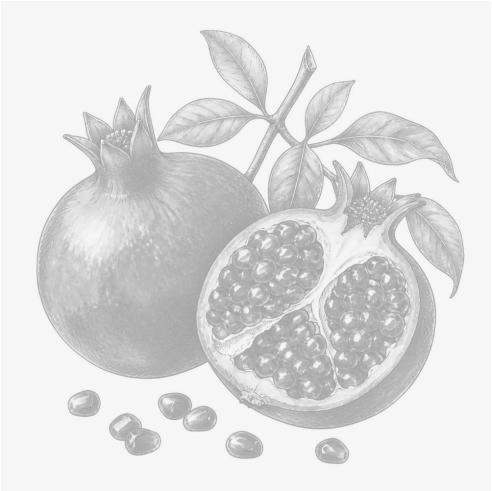
and rescued us from our foes,
for his steadfast love endures forever.

he who gives food to all flesh,
for his steadfast love endures forever.

Give thanks to the God of heaven,
for his steadfast love endures forever.

PARTNER B: READ THE BOLD LINES.

His Love *Endures Forever*



PSALM 136:1-5, 23-26 (ESV)

Give thanks to the LORD, for he is good,
for his steadfast love endures forever.

Give thanks to the God of gods,
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Give thanks to the Lord of lords,
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It is he who remembered us in our low estate,
for his steadfast love endures forever.

and rescued us from our foes,
for his steadfast love endures forever.

he who gives food to all flesh,
for his steadfast love endures forever.

Give thanks to the God of heaven,
for his steadfast love endures forever.

ONE READER LEADS. EVERYONE ANSWERS.

Still *Thankful*

A litany for the beautifully messy table.

For the turkey that took six hours to cook and ten minutes to eat,

still thankful.

For the mystery dish nobody can identify,

still thankful.

For the oven that ran out of room at the worst possible moment,

still thankful.

For the conversation that got a little too spicy,

still thankful.

For the empty seat that makes this year feel different,

still thankful.

For the dishes. All of them. Every single one.

Still thankful. (Mostly.)

For grace that shows up even when the gravy doesn't,

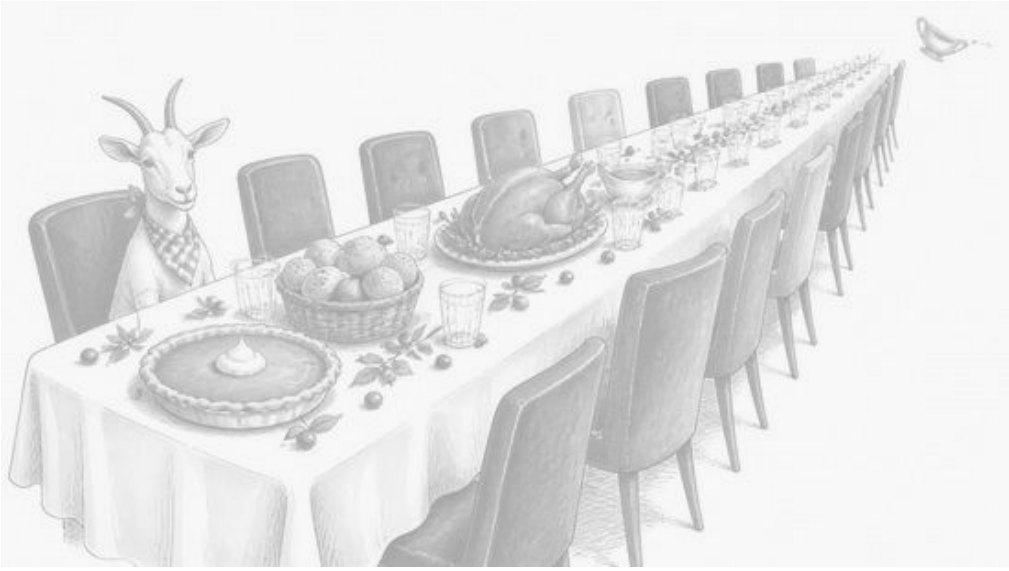
still thankful.

For a God who loves us right in the middle of the mess,

still thankful. Amen.



messy counts



ONE READER. DRAMATIC READING ENCOURAGED.

The Table *That Grew*

We set the table. Eight chairs. Cute.
Good napkins out. The fancy fruit.
Then somebody said, "Hey. I'm grateful for you."
The table went CREEEAK. And the table grew.

One more leaf. One more chair.
One more plate that wasn't there.
"Thanks for the pie!" (Store-bought. We know.)
Six more chairs. Now it's a show.

"Thanks for the rolls!" It hit the door.
"Thanks for the gravy!" It wanted more.
"Thanks for doing dishes without being asked!"
(Gasp.) It shot through the yard so fast
it rumbled downtown past the bakery and bank,
and everyone it passed sat down to give thanks:
the mail carrier, the mayor, the guy from the gym,
a goat from the zoo. (Nobody invited him.)

Now it's three miles long, or so I've heard.
The gravy boat set sail. (Absurd.)
Nobody's leaving. There's room for one more.
There always is.
That's what thank-yous are for.

goat not included

ROUND-ROBIN: ONE LIMERICK PER PERSON

Limericks, *Please*

The Long Grace

A guest said the grace with such zeal,
he blessed every bite of the meal.
When he finally said, "Amen,"
it was quarter to ten,
and we'd all aged a year. For real.

The Pie Debate

Our table can't settle on pie:
it's pumpkin, pecan, or we die.
So the host, quite the sage,
put an end to the rage
with a slice of each, stacked up high.

The Second Helping

A guest ate much more than he should,
then announced that he felt really good.
He unbuttoned his pants,
did a small victory dance,
and napped like a log made of wood.

The Casserole

The green bean casserole came,
as it does every year, just the same.
Nobody's sure
who it's actually for,
but skip it one year and you're blamed.

Pass It On

When thanks gets passed round like the peas,
it grows and it spreads like a breeze.
Say one to your neighbor.
It costs you no labor,
and soon the whole table's at ease.

silly voices win



ONE READER, OR PASS IT AROUND

Fun Facts *for the Table*

1621.

The harvest feast at Plymouth lasted about three days, with roughly 90 Wampanoag men and about 50 colonists. Venison and wildfowl were on the menu. Pie probably wasn't. No ovens, very little sugar.

1863.

After 17 years of letter writing by Sarah Josepha Hale, Abraham Lincoln made Thanksgiving a national holiday.

1924.

The first Macy's parade in New York borrowed live animals from the Central Park Zoo. Bears and elephants, marching down the street.

1939.

President Franklin Roosevelt moved Thanksgiving up a week to stretch the holiday shopping season. Critics called it "Franksgiving." For two years, states couldn't agree on which Thursday to celebrate. In 1941 Congress settled it: the fourth Thursday in November.

1953.

As the story goes, Swanson ended up with tons of leftover turkey and invented the TV dinner to use it up.

1981.

Butterball opened its Turkey Talk-Line, and it still helps panicked cooks every November.



trivia champ gets first slice

ONE READER

Better *Together*

ECCLESIASTES 4:9-12 (ESV)

Two are better than one, because they have a good reward for their toil. For if they fall, one will lift up his fellow. But woe to him who is alone when he falls and has not another to lift him up! Again, if two lie together, they keep warm, but how can one keep warm alone? And though a man might prevail against one who is alone, two will withstand him—a threefold cord is not quickly broken.



who lifted you up this year?

ONE READER TELLS THE STORY. EVERYONE SINGS.

Now Thank *We All Our God*

Martin Rinkart was a pastor in Eilenburg, Germany, during the Thirty Years' War. As the story is told, when plague swept through the crowded walled town in 1637, he was the last pastor left and buried thousands of people, including his own wife. In those same hard years he wrote a short prayer of thanks for the table. We still sing it.

"NOW THANK WE ALL OUR GOD," VERSE 1. TRANSLATED BY CATHERINE WINKWORTH, 1858

Now thank we all our God
with heart and hands and voices,
who wondrous things has done,
in whom this world rejoices;
who from our mothers' arms
has blessed us on our way
with countless gifts of love,
and still is ours today.

Sing it. badly is fine.

EVERYONE, TOGETHER

A Quiet *Moment*

Thirty seconds. Phones down. Nobody has to say anything.

"Be still, and know that I am God."

PSALM 46:10 (ESV)

The LORD your God is in your midst, a mighty one who will save; he will rejoice over you with gladness; he will quiet you by his love; he will exult over you with loud singing.

ZEPHANIAH 3:17 (ESV)



30 seconds. you can do it.



clink gently. good glasses.

EVERYONE, GLASSES UP

Raise Whatever's *in Your Glass*

Wine, cider, sparkling water, the last of the cranberry juice. All glasses count.

The Toast Round: go around the table and toast the person on your right. One sentence. No speeches. (We see you.)

Need a starter?

- "Here's to the time you…"
- "Here's to you for showing up when…"
- "Here's to the way you always…"
- "Here's to the person who taught me…"
- "Here's to next year, when you finally…"

EVERYONE, TOGETHER

May the road rise to meet you.
May the wind be always at your back.
May the sun shine warm upon your face,
the rains fall soft upon your fields,
and until we meet again,
may God hold you in the palm of His hand.

TRADITIONAL IRISH BLESSING

READ TOGETHER

To Close

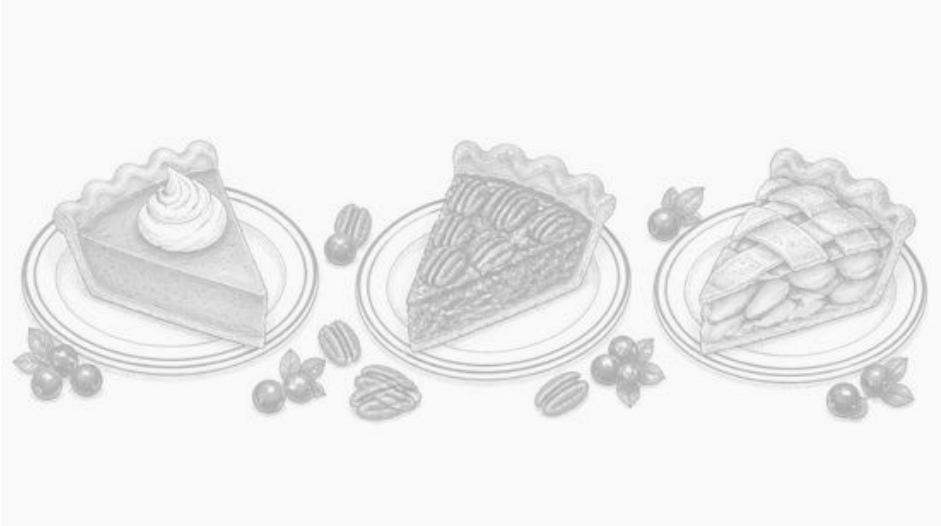
NUMBERS 6:24-26 (ESV)

The LORD bless you and keep you;
the LORD make his face to shine upon you and be gracious to you;
the LORD lift up his countenance upon you and give you peace.

Now go around the table one more time. Each person: one thing you're thankful for, in five words or less.

hugs optional. pie mandatory.





BONUS: KEEP THE TABLE TALKING

Pass the *Questions*

1. Ten people were healed, and only one came back to say thank you (Luke 17:11-19). Where do you think the other nine went? Be honest. Which one are you most years?
2. What's something you're grateful for now that you complained about at the time?
3. Who taught you something you never thanked them for? (Bonus points: text them before dessert.)
4. What's the best thing that happened to you this year that nobody at this table knows about?
5. What tiny thing turned an ordinary day into a great one this year?
6. If this table could have one more chair, who would you put in it?
7. Which dish would you fight for, and which one could disappear forever?
8. What's a hard thing from this year that taught you something good?
9. What do you hope you're thanking God for this time next year?

Pick one. Pass it on.

BONUS: FOR THE LULL BETWEEN PIE AND NAPS

Table *Games*

Gratitude ABCs

Go around the table. Each person names something they're thankful for, starting with the next letter of the alphabet. Stuck on Q or X? Creativity counts. Anyone who says "quiche" gets extra pie.

Guess Who's Grateful

Everyone writes one thing they're thankful for on a slip of paper, folds it and drops it in a bowl. Read them out loud one at a time. Guess who wrote each one. Wrong guesses get booed, lovingly.

The Great Pie Debate

Pumpkin, pecan or apple. Each team gets 30 seconds to make its case. The table votes. The losing side still gets pie, because we're not monsters.

Two Truths and a Turkey

Say two true things about your year and one made-up thing. The table guesses which one is the turkey.

Worst Thanksgiving Ever

Tell your most chaotic holiday story. Burnt bird, lost luggage, the year of the fire alarm. The table votes, and the winner picks first slice.



loser does dishes?

The Seconds, Please *Playlist*



kitchen dance party approved

Kitchen Chaos

Walking on Sunshine · Katrina and the Waves
Here Comes the Sun · The Beatles
Lovely Day · Bill Withers
Gravy (For My Mashed Potatoes) · Dee Dee Sharp
Ain't No Mountain High Enough · Marvin Gaye and Tammi Terrell

Grace and Gathering

Gratitude · Brandon Lake
Goodness of God · CeCe Winans
10,000 Reasons · Matt Redman
Blessings · Laura Story
Thank God I Do · Lauren Daigle

At the Table

What a Wonderful World · Louis Armstrong
Feeling Good · Nina Simone
Thank You · Dido
Home · Phillip Phillips

Dishes and Dancing

Celebration · Kool and the Gang
Lean on Me · Bill Withers
Thank You for Being a Friend · Andrew Gold
You've Got a Friend in Me · Randy Newman

Scan to play the whole thing on Spotify. **Bonus track for the brave:** Alice's Restaurant by Arlo Guthrie, a Thanksgiving classic that runs 18 minutes all by itself.

Thank You
for Being Here

Chaotic Sunshine

Made with love (and pie) by Chaotic Sunshine. Faith for the beautifully messy days.

Show us your table! Tag **@chaoticsunshinetable** on Instagram.

Want more? Get the Sunshine Mail newsletter and our free guides at

chaoticsunshine.com.

Coming next: **O Come, All Ye Tired**, a 25-day Advent guide for people who showed up tired.

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Lincoln's 1863 Thanksgiving Proclamation, "Now Thank We All Our God" (tr. Catherine Winkworth) and the traditional Irish blessing are in the public domain.

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One Sunday a month.

Sunshine Mail is a free monthly letter from Amy Grace: a Bible passage, an honest reflection, and something small to carry into your day.

scan me.
it's free.

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